

Reading Symptoms and the Site Vocabulary

Working backwards from what you can see to what is causing it, plus the terms and two numbers this domain asks for.

YOU HAVE MISSED THIS 2 TIMES

Rafter spread can be visually identified by:

Soffits pulling away from the house wall.

A roof pushes outward as well as downward. If the ties holding the rafter feet together fail, the walls are pushed apart at the top — and the first visible sign is at the eaves, where the soffit separates from the wall it was fixed to. Look at the joint, not at the roof.

Leaking humidifier

Its most serious implication is rusting of the heat exchanger. The humidifier itself is cheap; the heat exchanger it is dripping onto is the part whose failure puts combustion gases into the supply air.

That is the shape of a "most serious implication" question: not what is broken, but what the broken thing will destroy next. Follow the water and ask what it lands on.

The vocabulary

Topography

The natural features of the land.

Underground storage tank

Tanks located underground and used for the bulk storage of chemicals and petroleum. An abandoned one is an environmental liability, and you report the evidence — a vent pipe, a fill cap — rather than the tank you cannot see.

The numbers here

Minimum width for a concrete or asphalt driveway

8 ft

Vegetation should be cut back from a structure by at least

1 ft

YOU HAVE MISSED THIS 4 TIMES

The minimum width for a concrete or asphalt driveway is:

Eight feet.

YOU HAVE MISSED THIS 3 TIMES

Vegetation should be cut back ____ from a structure.

At least one foot.

Eight feet is a car with the doors opening. One foot of clearance keeps plants from holding moisture against the siding and from bridging a path for insects into the wall.

How to work

YOU HAVE MISSED THIS 3 TIMES

Common inspector mistakes include all of the following EXCEPT:

Going back and checking things you may have overlooked.

Going back to re-check is good practice, not a mistake — which is what makes it the exception. The real mistakes are rushing, working out of sequence, relying on memory instead of notes, and letting a talkative client pull you off your routine.

The numbers here

Thorough inspection of a typical property takes about

3 hours

Say it back

Cover the page. Answer each one out loud.

1. How is rafter spread identified visually, and why does it show there?
2. Most serious implication of a leaking humidifier?
3. Define topography, and say what you report about an underground storage tank.
4. Minimum driveway width, and vegetation clearance?
5. Which common-mistake option is the exception, and why?
6. How long should a thorough inspection take?